Light-GIVE constructions in Malayalam and Tamil*

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1. Introduction

Dravidian languages display a kind of construction wherein a verb that canonically has the meaning of 'give' is used to introduce an argument with a particular semantics to a verb. This overall pattern is not typologically unusual, as it is observed, for example, in the Kwa languages (Shluinsky 2017), and Korean and Japanese (Tomioka and Kim 2017). Examples of this are shown below from Malayalam (1a) and Tamil (1b) (note: Dravidian languages are head-final, and have SOV as the default word order). We call these *light*-GIVE *constructions* (LGCs).

(1) a. Rāmaṉ Gōvindaṉ-ŭ tamiḻ paṭipiccŭ=koṭuttu.
Raman.NOM Govindan-DAT Tamil teach.PTCP=give.PST
'Raman taught Govindan Tamil.' (Malayalam)

b. Rāmaṉ Gōvindaṉ-ŭkkŭ tamiḻ kattŭ=kuḍŭ-tt-āṉ.
Raman.NOM Govindan-DAT Tamil teach.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M
'Raman taught Govindan Tamil.' (Tamil)

In Malayalam and Tamil, the light verb GIVE[1] follows a lexical verb which takes its own direct object (henceforth 'DO'). The introduced argument is marked by the dative case, and precedes the DO, as is typical of an indirect object (henceforth 'IO'). The typical role of GIVE in these constructions cross-linguistically is often assumed to be the introduction of a 'Benefactive' argument. In the case above, Govindan could be the beneficiary of a teaching event, but he also appears to receive the DO in some sense.

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[1]From here, we use the notation GIVE to refer to cases of this morpheme being used as a light verb.

Other examples of this construction exhibit different characteristics. For example, in (2)[2], the main event is the opening of a door, and there is no "giving" event, or any transfer of possession.

(2) a. Ñāṉ niṉakkŭ vātil tuṟannŭ=tar-ām.
1SG 2SG.DAT door open.PTCP=give-POT
'I will open the door for you.' (Malayalam, Jayaseelan 2004:83)

b. Rājā Kumār-ŭkkŭ katavai tiṟantŭ=kuḍŭ-tt-āṉ.
Raja.NOM Kumar-DAT door open.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M
'Raja opened the door for Kumar.' (Tamil, Lehmann 1993:227)

This calls into question what kind of structure is used in this construction, and how that contributes to its meaning. In this paper we seek to address two things: first, what kind of syntactic structure is at play in LGCs in these two languages, and second, what accounts for the range of interpretations they can have. In the next section we will review two previous analyses which make rather different predictions, and show that neither of these account fully for the behavior of LGCs. In Section 3 we will propose a new syntactic and semantic analysis for this construction, arguing that this is syntactically underlying a double-object construction, but with atypical semantics. We finish in Section 4 with some conclusions and outlook.

2. Previous analyses

Aside from a few examples of LGCs provided in grammars (e.g., Lehmann 1993), we are aware of only two major discussions of the syntax and semantics of LGCs in Malayalam and Tamil, that of Jayaseelan (2004) and Sundaresan (2006)[3]. We present and discuss their analyses below and will argue that while neither approach has sufficient empirical coverage by itself, both provide valuable insight into the phenomena that leads us to our own proposal in Section 3.

Jayaseelan (2004) interprets the LGC in Malayalam to have the meaning that the subject gives the IO (the result of) the event expressed by the lexical verb. While he stops short of suggesting a full account of how these semantics are derived, the underlying intuition is critical, as it explains why, when an event such as a door opening is used within an LGC, the door itself is not interpreted as being 'given' to the IO. On this basis, Jayaseelan analyzes the Malayalam LGC as an embedding structure, where GIVE is the main verb of the matrix clause, to whose argument structure the subject and "benefactive" IO belong. The other

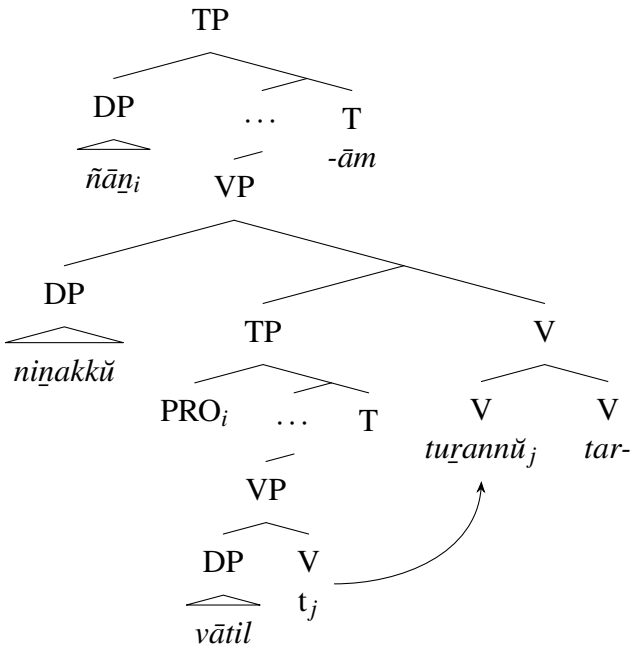
[2]In Malayalam, there are two stems used for 'give' in both lexical and light verb contexts: *tar-* is used if the IO is the perspective holder, and *koṭuCC-* is used otherwise.

[3]A third proposal worth mentioning is that of Lidz (2002) who analyzes LGCs in Kannada, another Dravidian language. Unfortunately, some of the diagnostics that he employs to identify the relative position of the IO and DO in Kannada LGCs, particularly those involving binding and scope, cannot be replicated in Tamil and Malayalam. His proposal is ultimately very close to that of Sundaresan (2006) so we will not discuss it separately.

verb belongs to an embedded (non-finite) clause. The subjects of the two clauses are co-identified via control: the subject position of the lower clause is occupied by a PRO, which is bound by the subject of the matrix clause. This gives the construction a very similar structure to ditransitive control verbs in English, e.g. *Riley$_i$ promised Kai* [PRO$_i$ *to fix the sink*], and very different from raising verbs (which are never ditransitive in English), e.g. *Taylor$_i$ seems* [____$_i$ *to have fixed the sink*].

A key feature of Jayaseelan's analysis of LGCs is how he derives the linear adjacency requirement of GIVE and the lexical verb. Jayaseelan proposes that the lexical verb undergoes some kind of head-movement to adjoin to GIVE. This forces the two to be adjacent, which appears to be necessary since the embedded TP is a direct object, and elements can otherwise intervene between the verb and its object(s) in Malayalam. We adapt Jayaseelan's structure for (2a) below in (3).

(3)



The overall prediction of this analysis is that each of the verbs inhabit their own clause and project independent argument structures. Moreover, as mentioned above, the subject is shared between the lexical verb and GIVE via control, meaning both the subject and PRO are θ-marked by each verb. We will argue against these predictions in what follows.

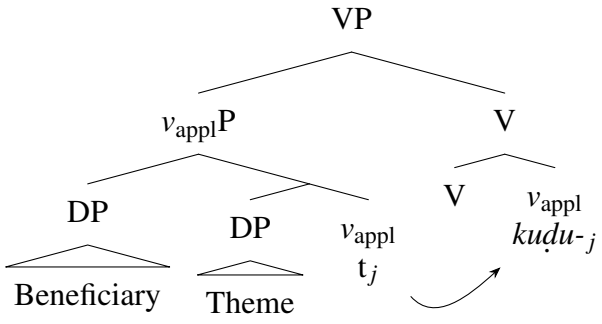
In contrast to Jayaseelan's biclausal analysis of LGCs, Sundaresan (2006) treats LGCs as a kind of low applicative in Pylkkänen's (2008) terms. She shows that rather than patterning with English *for*-PP benefactives, LGCs behave like English double-object constructions (henceforth 'DOCs') in, for example, requiring that the beneficiary exist and be animate. This is illustrated for Tamil below in examples (4a) and (4b) (adapted from Sundaresan 2006:392). She additionally argues that the dative argument in LGCs must be interpreted as receiving the Theme argument, but we will contest this claim.

(4) a. Rāman tan manaivi-kkŭ dosai-ye vāttŭ=kuḍŭ-tt-ān (# ānā
Raman.NOM self wife-DAT crepe-ACC bake.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M (but
avan-ŭkkŭ innum kalyāṇam-ē āga-le!)
he-DAT still marriage-EMPH happen-NEG)
'Raman baked his wife crepes (#but he isn't even married yet!)' (Tamil)

b. #Rāman paricce-kkŭ pustagatt-e vāngi=kuḍŭ-tt-ān.
Raman.NOM exam-DAT book-ACC buy.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M
Intended: 'Raman bought the book for the exam.'

Sundaresan also notes that LGCs are incompatible with certain classes of verbs, namely, so-called 'Obtain'-verbs like *accept* and *accumulate*, and 'Selection'-verbs like *indicate* and *prefer* (terminology adopted from Levin 1993). These facts are all accounted for by a low applicative analysis since the semantics of a low applicative (Recipient) relate the DO and IO to each other via a *to-the-possession* relation, which can only be true if the IO exists and is a possible possessor. The advantage of this approach is also that it correctly predicts that LGCs are incompatible with unergative and stative predicates and allow subject and DO depictives, but not IO depictives[4] (properties of the type of low applicatives that Pylkkänen 2008 analyzes). Similar to Jayaseelan, Sundaresan is forced to assume some head movement, in this case positing that the low applicative head spelled out as GIVE, moves to adjoin to the head of the lexical verb in order to derive the correct order of the lexical and light verb.

(5)



2.1 Problems with extant analyses

The approaches of Jayaseelan and Sundaresan face distinct issues. While Jayaseelan correctly intuits a semantic relation between the IO and the lexical verb's event rather than the IO itself, his syntactic implementation fails by trying to retrofit the lexical meaning of GIVE into an analysis of this otherwise idiosyncratic construction. This diverges from the empirical picture in two ways: first, by assigning GIVE and the lexical verb separate clauses

[4]A full discussion of depictives is outside of the scope of this paper, but we will take for granted that Sundaresan is correct about these constructions patterning with low applicatives in this respect.

and argument structures, he incorrectly predicts that a lower ditransitive verb should permit two independent IOs (e.g., a Beneficiary for GIVE and a Recipient for the lexical verb). In reality, Malayalam and Tamil LGCs strictly limit the number of IOs to one across the whole construction. As demonstrated in (6), while the ditransitive lexical verb *send* can appear in an LGC, the construction forbids an additional dative argument:

(6) a. Avaṉ innale eṉṉikkŭ fōṭō āyiccu.
3SG.M yesterday 1SG.DAT photo send.PST
'He sent me the photo yesterday.' (Malayalam)

b. Avaṉ (*Sīta-ykkŭ) innale eṉṉikkŭ fōṭō āyiccŭ=tannu.
3SG.M Sita-DAT yesterday 1SG.DAT photo send.PTCP=give.PST
'He sent me the photo (*for Sita) yesterday.'

Second, a control structure is inadequate because GIVE does not express a separate event; therefore, the subject cannot be θ-marked by GIVE. Without an independent Agent θ-role assigned by GIVE, control lacks motivation. The upshot is that LGCs and DOCs utilize the same structure to introduce IOs, and possess only one external argument, since GIVE and the lexical verb do not express separate events. This implies a much more condensed structure than what Jayaseelan proposes: LGCs *are* essentially DOCs with deviant morphosyntax and semantics, which is indeed very close to what Sundaresan suggests.

Sundaresan's proposal, however, also lacks empirical coverage. As alluded to before, she claims that LGCs necessarily have a semantics where the DO is transferred. However, this overlooks the availability of LGCs with predicates like 'door open' (as in (2b)) which trivially do not involve the IO taking possession of the DO. What does seem to be the case is that the lexical semantics of the main verb in LGCs determines whether the IO is interpreted as a recipient or merely a beneficiary, with only verbs that involve the creation ('cook', 'sew', 'grow', etc.) or transfer ('send', 'teach', 'buy', etc.) of the DO forcing a recipient reading. We also agree that LGCs are incompatible with statives and unergatives, but note that they are in fact impossible with unaccusatives as well, as in (7), which has not been previously described to the best of our knowledge.

(7) *Rāmaṉ Gōvindaṉ-ŭkkŭ vandŭ=kuḍu-tt-āṉ.
Raman.NOM Govindan-DAT come.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M
Intended: 'Raman came for Govindan.' (Tamil)

An additional observation about LGCs is that they must be interpreted as referring to telic events, even if the lexical verb(-phrase)s they are built on can otherwise refer to atelic events. This is illustrated in Malayalam below in (8).

(8) a. Orŭ māsa-ttekkŭ Rāmaṉ vīṭŭ paṇi ceytu.
one month-DAT Raman.NOM house work do.PST
Intended: 'Raman did work on a house for one month.' (Malayalam)

b. *Orŭ māsa-ttekkŭ Rāmaṉ Gōvindaṉ-ŭ vīṭŭ paṇi ceytŭ=koṭuttu.
one month-DAT Raman.NOM Govindan-DAT house work do.PTCP=give.PST
Intended: 'Raman did work on a house for Govindan for one month.'

Neither the incompatibility with unaccusatives nor the forced telicity fall out of the analyses reviewed above. Finally, a problem that is common to both approaches above is that in order to correctly derive the linear order and adjacency of the lexical verb and GIVE, some kind of head movement must be assumed. In both analyses, this is an *ad hoc* assumption which lacks independent motivation.

Despite our critiques, we stress that both analyses draw upon valid intuitions, and fall short only because they do not consider the full range of data. On our view, Jayaseelan's semantic idea is fundamentally correct — that what is being "given" in an LGC is the outcome of the event expressed by the main verb. At the same time, Sundaresan's understanding of the LGC as syntactically parallel to a DOC is also correct. A complete analysis must incorporate both of these ideas; we will attempt to do just that in what follows.

3. Proposal

Having discussed Jayaseelan and Sundaresan's proposals and shown how both face empirical challenges, we will now provide our analysis of LGCs that incorporates insights from both previous approaches. The facts that we aim to capture are the following: (i) LGCs, like DOCs, license only a single IO position, (ii) the light verb GIVE, which seems to license the IO, is directly adjacent to the lexical verb, (iii) LGCs cannot be built on either unaccusatives or unergatives, (iv) LGCs are incompatible with stative predicates, as well as with Levin's 'Selection'- and 'Obtain'-verbs, and (v) the interpretation of the IO as a recipient or beneficiary is predictably conditioned by the lexical semantics of the main verb that the LGC is built on. In order to account for all of these, we must separate the syntactic facts from the semantic ones. Syntactically, we will propose that canonical DOCs mostly overlap in structural configuration with LGCs in these languages, such that 'give' spells out a head which licenses the IO. Semantically, we will argue that the distinction between LGCs and DOCs comes from the semantics of the participle in conjunction with the unique semantics of GIVE.

3.1 The syntax of LGCs

Starting with the syntax, we can straightforwardly interpret the evidence that only one IO position can be saturated in LGCs to mean that regular DOCs and LGCs to some extent share a common structure in relation to the position in which an IO is licensed. This can be modelled in terms of abstract Case or positional licensing.

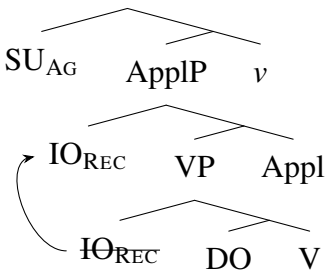
Little hinges on the assumptions we make about how canonical DOCs work syntactically, with one exception: we will assume that the surface position of the IO is higher than VP. As such, we will follow Georgala's (2012) *raising applicative* analysis, under which the IO is generated within VP, where the standard 'low applicative' semantics are derived,

and then raises to the specifier of a higher ApplP[5], itself selected by the external argument-introducing *v*P, shown in (9a). Georgala's analysis provides a modest benefit, which is that the exact semantics of the IO in a DOC may vary depending on the lexical verb itself, rather than a syntactically independent category; this may be generally helpful, since verbs like 'give,' 'send,' and 'teach' all have similar, but not identical semantics for the IO.

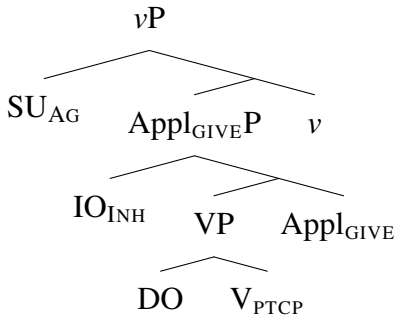
Along these lines, let us assume that there is a single position in the clausal spine where the assignment of structural dative case (i.e. the licensing of IOs) takes place[6]. We will assume that this is the specifier of an applicative phrase ApplP (following Marantz 1993, and as in Georgala 2012), which itself has the following distribution: it can only ever be the complement of *v*, the External Argument-introducing head, and it always takes as its complement a VP, which contains the lexical verb. We will assume that this is a category-selection issue in the syntax, i.e. Appl^0 selects VP, and v^0 selects ApplP. The derivation thus proceeds as follows:

(1) V and the DO merge, forming VP. (2) VP merges with Appl^0, forming Appl'. (3) The IO merges with Appl', forming ApplP. (4) Appl^0 assigns dative case to the IO. (5) v^0 merges with ApplP, forming v'. (6) v^0 assigns accusative case to the DO. (7) The subject (SU) merges with v', forming *v*P. (8) T^0 merges with *v*P, forming T′. (9) T^0 assigns nominative case to the SU. What is critical about this sequence is that we assume that the assignment of the dative case applies after Appl' merges with the IO, whereas v^0, T^0, etc. assign case to the highest caseless DP they c-command immediately upon merging[7]. This then gives us the structure in (9b):

(9) a.



b.



LGCs also follow this template neatly, with three differences: first, GIVE spells out the Appl^0 head (typically lacking specific morphology); second, the VP's participial morphology prevents further inflection; and third, External Merge fills the IO position, instead of

[5]In other words, low and high applicatives have the same surface structure w.r.t. the position of the Spec,ApplP.

[6]While this correlates by default with the morphological dative case, we will not consider the case morphology of IOs for our analysis.

[7]This is necessary if the case-assignment behavior of *v* and T are taken to be otherwise consistent. Of course, an alternative would be that Appl^0 is itself a variant of *v* and assigns accusative case, and *v* is somehow sensitive to having an ApplP complement and in such a configuration, assigns dative to the highest c-commanded DP.

raising à la Georgala. This distinction (i.e. base-generation in Spec,ApplP, rather than raising to Spec,ApplP) informs the subsequent semantics. This also means that only one IO can be licensed between the lexical verb and GIVE, as exactly one licensing position exists. Additionally, because selecting ApplP requires an external argument-introducing head, LGCs cannot be built on unaccusatives. Finally, this analysis eliminates the need for head-movement to force linear adjacency between the lexical verb and GIVE; since these languages are uniformly head-final, the head of Appl's complement naturally sits immediately to its left.

3.2 The semantics of LGCs

For the semantics, our goal is to capture Jayaseelan's intuition that LGCs express that the subject "gives" the result state of the event denoted by the lexical verb to the IO, rather than the DO itself. We therefore propose a special semantic variant of the applicative head that we call $\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}$ which asserts that the argument in the specifier of the applicative phrase is the "recipient" of a state which holds of the DO. This state is introduced within the VP by an operator that is spelled out as the participial morphology on the lexical verb[8]. The idea that participles contain states in their denotations in addition to events is in line with Kratzer (2000), whose denotation for participial stems we adopt, as shown below in (10).

(10) $[\![\text{verb.PTCP}]\!] = \lambda x_e \lambda s_v \lambda e_v [\text{verb-ing}(e) \wedge \text{verb-ed}(x)(s) \wedge \text{CAUSE}(s)(e)]$.

Unlike the root, the participial stem assigns to its DP complement the role of holder of the 'verb-ed' result state rather than Theme of the 'verb-ing' event. The denotation of the LGC applicative head is then the following:

(11) $[\![\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}]\!] = \lambda R_{<v,<v,t>>} \lambda x_e \lambda e_v \exists s [R(s)(e) \wedge \text{INHERITOR}(x)(s)]$.

The $\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}$ head existentially quantifies over the state argument introduced by the participial stem and then relates it to the argument in its specifier by a relation we term the *Inheritor*, a generalized relation which is one of having custodial status over the result state of the event. This allows us to account for the role of the lexical semantics of the main verb in determining whether the IO is interpreted as a recipient or a beneficiary. In particular, when the lexical verb is one of creation or transfer for example, such as 'cook' or 'buy', the IO having custody over a 'cooked' or 'bought' state holding of a DO will necessarily entail that the IO is in possession of the holder of that state. If no such creation or transfer is involved, as in the case of 'open', then the most logical interpretation of the IO is that of a beneficiary of the result state.

In line with Marantz (1984) and Kratzer (1996), we take the subject to be related to the event structure by the *v* head, which assigns it the role of Agent of the event denoted by the lexical verb. The denotation of the *v*P in a sentence like in (2b), repeated below in (12), would thus be as in (13):

[8] It is not crucial to us that participial morphology spells out an operator within the VP, but we adopt this idea in order to avoid positing that verb roots and participial stems are stored as separate lexical items with distinct but related denotation.

(12) Rājā Kumār-ŭkkŭ katavai tiṟantŭ=kuḍŭ-tt-āṉ.
Raja.NOM Kumar-DAT door open.PTCP=give-PST-3SG.M
'Raja opened the door for Kumar.' (Tamil, Lehmann 1993:227)

(13) $[\![vP_{(12)}]\!] = \lambda e_v \exists s[\text{opening}(e) \wedge \text{opened}(\textit{door})(s) \wedge \textsc{Cause}(s)(e) \wedge \textsc{Inheritor}(\text{Kumār})(s) \wedge \textsc{Agent}(\text{Rājā})(e)]$.

Such semantics for LGCs have a number of advantages, aside from yielding the recipient-beneficiary alternation. First, the impossibility of building an LGC on an unergative is a result of the requirement that the state-holder argument position in the VP be saturated in order for VP to compose with $\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}$. Second, the incompatibility with statives and the forced telicity are both a consequence of the fact that LGCs assert the existence of result states of the events denoted by their lexical verbs. And finally, we propose that the restriction against Levin's 'Obtain'- and 'Selection'-verbs is more a pragmatic one than semantic or syntactic, since these are verbs whose lexical semantics imply that the Agent itself is the recipient or beneficiary of the DO.

4. Conclusions and outlook

In this paper, we have proposed a unified syntactic and semantic analysis of LGCs in Malayalam and Tamil, reconciling the empirical shortcomings of previous biclausal and low-applicative approaches. Syntactically, LGCs parallel canonical double-object constructions, wherein the light verb GIVE spells out an applicative head Appl, which in turn structurally licenses a single indirect object. We proposed that the unique semantics can be derived via a specialized $\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}$ head, which existentially quantifies over a result state introduced by a VP-internal "participializer" and relates it to the indirect object via the Inheritor relation. By requiring the IO to possess custodial status over the result state of the event, we explain why LGCs must be interpreted as telic, why they resist stative predicates, and predictably shift their interpretation based on the main verb's lexical semantics. An interesting outcome of this analysis is that there is no blanket incompatibility with intransitives; rather different kinds of intransitives are incompatible for different reasons. Unaccusative lexical verbs are ruled out because ApplP is only ever selected by *v* in the syntax, whereas unergatives are ruled out because states require holders, and thus the VP complement of $\text{Appl}_{\text{GIVE}}$ must contain an argument. Both of these ultimately arise due to discrepancies between the possible syntax/semantics of Appl and intransitives, but the two effects are not attributable to the same restriction. Looking at the bigger picture, our analysis reinforces the increasingly common idea that semantic roles and syntactic argument licensing should be thought of as dissociated behaviors in grammar.

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